favour of giving nuclear weapons to Pakistan. [8] The Americans had already guessed that China was assisting Pakistan, and Kissinger was seeking affirmation from the Chinese. Deng did not rise to the bait. Silence was invariably used as a tactic whenever the Chinese did not wish to address any matter. This also allowed for deniability about China's involvement in Pakistan's nuclear programme. When Prime Ministers Rajiv Gandhi and Narasimha Rao would subsequently raise the supply by China to Pakistan of M-11 nuclear-capable missiles and ring magnets for centrifuges with Chinese leaders, there would be the same studied silence, the same denials.

China had stayed outside the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty's (NPT) ambit through the 1970s. However, in the 1980s, under Deng Xiaoping, China had begun to 'normalize' its dealings with the outside world. Deng's Modernization Programme needed both external financing and a stable geo-strategic environment, and he introduced consequent changes in how China dealt with the world. [9] On 17 March 1992, therefore, China formally acceded to the NPT. In 1995, during the NPT Review Conference, China gained first-hand experience in collaborating with the N-5 (five nuclear weapon states recognized in the NPT) as a group, and realized the benefits in terms of global influence as a result of being a member of such an exclusive club. It joined the other nuclear weapons states in supporting an indefinite extension of the NPT. This was in sharp contrast to what Deng Xiaoping had told Indian journalists in Beijing after meeting Foreign Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee in February 1979, namely that the nuclear powers had no right to ask other countries not to have nuclear weapons when the nuclear weapons states were not committing to eliminate their own nuclear weapons. [10] China had travelled a long way in just fifteen years.